



Fringe tree
is a valuable
tonic for the
liver, gallbladder,
and pancreas.

shrubby areas. The root is unearthed in spring or autumn, mostly in Virginia and North Carolina.

Parts Used Root bark, bark.

Constituents Contains saponins (including chionanthin) and glycosides (including phyllirine).

History & Folklore Fringe tree was commonly used by Native Americans and European settlers to treat inflammations of the eye, canker sores, and spongy gums. The Choctaw of Louisiana applied the mashed bark to cuts and bruises. Native Americans in Alabama used the bark as a treatment for toothache. In the 19th century Anglo-American Physiomedicalist tradition, fringe tree was valued as a bitter tonic, and the bark was often used to aid recovery from long-term illness.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The root bark is a liver tonic, stimulates bile flow, and acts as a mild laxative. It is prescribed mainly for gallbladder pain, gallstones, jaundice, and chronic weakness. While it appears to be of benefit to liver and gallbladder function, there is as yet no research to substantiate its effects. The root bark also appears to strengthen function in the pancreas and spleen. Anecdotal evidence indicates that it may substantially reduce sugar levels in the urine. Fringe tree also stimulates the appetite and digestion and is an excellent remedy for chronic illness, especially where the liver has been affected. For external use, the crushed bark may be made into a poultice for treating sores and wounds.

Chondrodendron tomentosum (Menispermaceae)

Pareira

Description Vine climbing to a great height in tropical rainforests. Reaches 100 ft (30 m). Has large leaves up to 1 ft (30 cm) long and trailing clusters of flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Pareira grows wild in rainforests in the upper Amazon region and in Panama. It is collected from the wild as available.

Parts Used Root, stem.

Constituents Pareira contains alkaloids, including delta-tubocurarine and L-curarine. Tubocurarine is a potent muscle relaxant.

History & Folklore Pareira and similar species are famous for being the source of curare, the paralyzing arrow poison used by Amazonian and other South American Indians to catch their prey. A dart or spear tipped with curare causes instantaneous paralysis on entering the bloodstream of the animal. Traditional recipes for toxins usually involve blending 10 or more different plants, but pareira or a plant with similar action is always present in the mix.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pareira's notoriety as a poison hinges on the effect of its toxic derivative entering directly into the bloodstream. Provided there are no cuts or sores in the mouth, the plant is reasonably safe taken orally as a medicinal remedy. The bitter and slightly sweet-tasting roots and stems are mildly laxative, tonic, and diuretic, and also act to induce menstruation. The plant is chiefly used to relieve chronic inflammation of the urinary tubules. In Brazil, it is also used for snake bite.

Research Pareira's powerful ability to paralyze has led to its being extensively researched. Tubocurarine—one of the many alkaloids within the plant—is now used (as tubocurarine chloride) as an anesthetic to paralyze the muscles during operations.

Related Species At least four other closely related species of *Chondrodendron* are used to produce the traditional poison known as curare.

⚠️ Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Pareira and/or curare are subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Chondrus crispus (Gigartinaceae)

Irish Moss, Carragheen

Description Reddish-brown seaweed growing to 10 in (25 cm). Plant body is flat and forked, with a fan-shaped outline.

Habitat & Cultivation Irish moss is found on the Atlantic coasts of Europe and North America. It grows just below the waterline, attached to rocks and stones. In summer in North America, and in autumn in Ireland, it is pulled up by hand or with a rake at low tide and dried in the sun.

Part Used Whole herb.

Constituents Irish moss contains large amounts of polysaccharides, proteins (up to 10%),

amino acids, iodine, and bromine, plus many other minerals. The polysaccharides become jelly-like and demulcent when the plant is immersed in water.

History & Folklore Irish moss is used extensively in the food and pharmaceutical industries as an emulsifying and binding agent, for example in toothpastes.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A useful demulcent and emollient, Irish moss is mainly taken for coughs and bronchitis. Its expectorant effect encourages the coughing up of phlegm, and it soothes dry and irritated mucous membranes. It is of value for acid indigestion, gastritis, and urinary infections such as cystitis. For these conditions it is normally combined with other appropriate herbs. Mucilaginous in texture and slightly salty in taste, Irish moss makes a valuable nutrient in convalescence. Applied externally, this emollient herb soothes inflamed skin. Irish moss also acts to thin the blood.

Caution Due to its blood-thinning property, carragheen should not be used by people taking anticoagulant medicines.

Cichorium intybus (Asteraceae)

Chicory

Description Deep-rooted perennial growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has a hairy stem, oblong leaves, and blue flowers.



Chicory leaves make a settling digestive tea.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, chicory also grows in North Africa and western Asia. It flourishes along paths and roadsides, and in banks and dry fields. The root is unearthed in spring or autumn.

Parts Used Root, leaves, flowers.

Constituents The root contains up to 58% inulin, caffeic acids, coumarins, flavonoids, polyynes, an essential oil including sesquiterpene lactones,